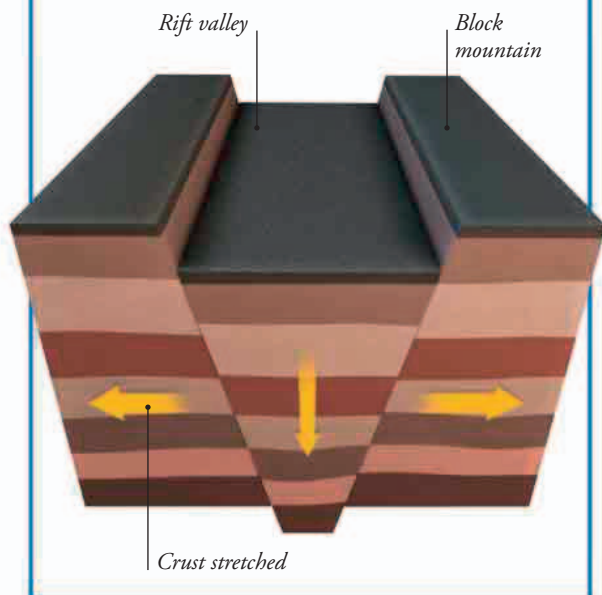


BLOCK MOUNTAINS

Sometimes, shifting plates can pull continents apart. The stretched rocks fracture, forming faults that allow big blocks of crust to slip downward and create rift valleys. The rocks on either side are left as block mountains. The African Great Rift Valley was formed like this.



HARD ROCK

The titanic earth movements that build mountains are often linked to processes that melt the rock beneath the crust. The molten rock seeps upward and slowly solidifies below ground. This creates huge masses of granite and other hard rock. Over time, the softer rock above may be worn away, slowly exposing the hard granite to form spectacular mountains. Similar processes may expose the cores of ancient volcanoes made of solidified lava.

▼ GRANITE GIANT

Half Dome in the Sierra Nevada range of California is a massive lump of exposed granite that originally formed deep below ground.

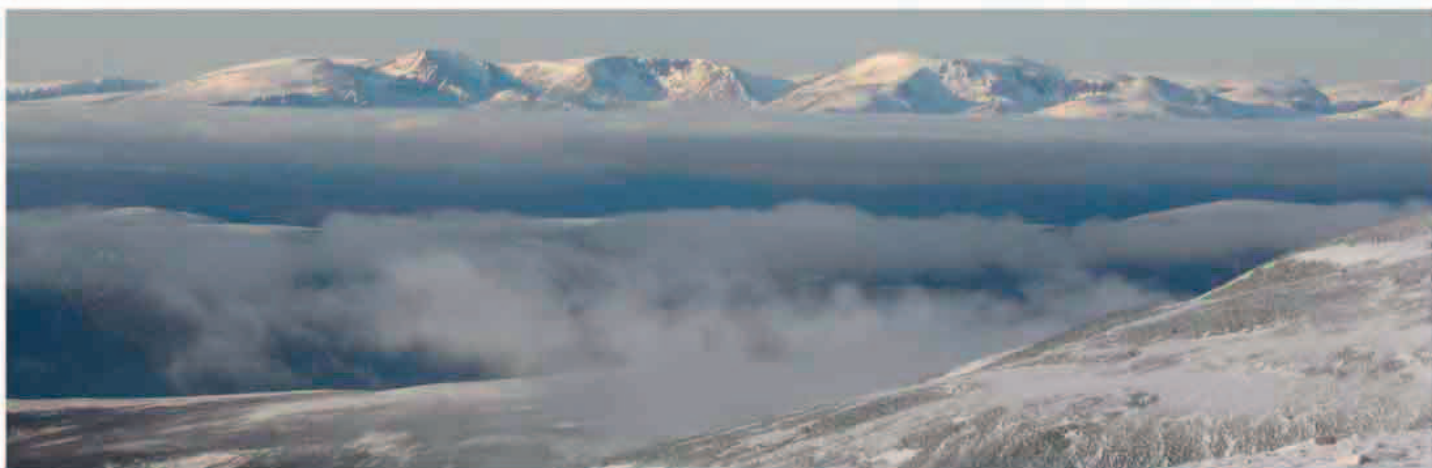


FADED GLORY

In time, all mountains fade away. They sink under their own weight like heaps of wet sand, and are worn away where the rock is exposed to the weather. If it weren't for the continuing movement of Earth's crust, they would all eventually vanish.

▼ RUGGED SURVIVORS

The once towering mountains of the Scottish Highlands have been gradually reduced to rounded stumps.



FAST FACTS

The "seven summits" are the highest individual peaks on each continent.

- **Asia** Everest: 29,029 ft (8,848 m), Himalayas, Nepal/China
- **South America** Aconcagua: 22,841 ft (6,962 m), Andes, Argentina
- **North America** Mount McKinley: 20,320 ft (6,194 m), Alaska Range, USA
- **Africa** Kilimanjaro: 19,341 ft (5,895 m), Kilimanjaro Range, Tanzania
- **Europe** Mount Elbrus: 18,510 ft (5,642 m), Caucasus, Chechnya, Russia
- **Antarctica** Vinson Massif: 16,500 ft (4,997 m), Ellsworth Mountains
- **Oceania** Puncak Jaya: 16,024 ft (4,884 m), Sudirman Range, New Guinea